

BUILDING THE FUTURE Far left, digital blackboard in a govt school at Bhadrak; the state-of-the-art sports training centre at Kalinga Stadium, Bhubaneswar

BJD as he believes the state BJP now has the strength to challenge and defeat Naveen. Many of Naveen's schemes, he says, are performing poorly and most of the development is restricted to key urban centres such as Puri, Cuttack and Bhubaneswar to the neglect of the rural areas in the state. He also alleges that there is massive unemployment among youth and Odisha has become the epicentre of migration. That Naveen is contesting from two assembly seats this time—his traditional Hinjili seat in Ganjam district and the Kantabanji constituency in Bolangir district—is being painted by the BJP as a sign of his being unsure of winning this time.

Pandian, though, dismisses any talk of Naveen's fading popularity or anti-incumbency. To illustrate his point, he cites the panchayat elections of March 2022, when the BJD captured all 30 districts, winning 765 of the 852 zilla parishad seats. Pandian is wisely contesting neither an assembly nor a parliamentary seat, which leaves him free to tour the state and blunt criticism about trying to succeed Naveen. Yet all is not well within the BJD either, with several of its prominent members defecting to the BJP in March 2024, including six-time Lok Sabha member and Cuttack MP Bhartruhari Mahtab and two-time MP Sidhant Mohapatra. The BJD struck back by getting two BJP leaders—vice-president Lekhasri Samantsinghar and Bhrugu Buxipatra—to switch sides. "Defections are happening on an industrial scale from both parties," says a senior Odisha political observer. To fulfil its commitment of reserving 33 per cent of Lok Sabha candidacies for women, the BJD has resorted to nominating the wives of sitting candidates to contest. This has helped stem rebellion from existing members who would otherwise have been denied tickets, while also attracting women voters.

ODISHA IS SEEING DEFECTIONS FROM THE BJD TO THE BJP AND VICE VERSA AT AN INDUSTRIAL SCALE, SAY EXPERTS

The BJP, on the other hand, even as it vociferously denounces Naveen, has so far not projected a CM candidate. Unlike Naveen who has stayed put in Odisha, the two BJP stalwarts, Dharmendra Pradhan and Baijayant Panda, who defected from the BJD in 2019, are not contesting assembly seats. Though the party's performance and vote share have improved over the years, the BJP still relies heavily on PM Modi. All this gives Naveen, with his clean image and track record of uplifting Odisha over the past two decades, a decisive edge in the assembly stakes. But only on June 4 will we know whether Naveen Patnaik will make history or be history. ■

–with Arkamoy Datta Majumdar